

Deep Dive: Self-Talk and Affirmations

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The second bookend to having confidence is learning to use affirmations and confidence anchors. Affirmations are positive, specific statements that help individuals overcome negative thoughts and self-sabotage.

The science behind affirmations lies in their ability to influence our subconscious mind. When we consistently repeat positive statements, we create new neural pathways that strengthen our positive self-beliefs. This process is known as *neuroplasticity*, where the brain adapts and reorganizes itself by forming new connections. In other words, by repeating certain affirmations every day, you can actually rewire your brain to think more constructively and have more confidence!

For example, someone struggling with self-esteem issues might use affirmations like, "I am worthy of love and respect," or "I am capable and confident." The effectiveness of affirmations depends on how they are phrased and used. Here are some key principles to consider:

Be Positive. Frame affirmations in a positive manner. Instead of saying, "I am not a failure," say, "I am successful in almost everything I do."

Be Present. Use the present tense to create a sense of immediacy. Affirmations should reflect the present moment, such as, "I am strong and resilient."

Be Specific. Tailor affirmations to address specific areas of concern or goals. For instance, if you want to boost your public speaking skills, an affirmation could be, "I am working every day to being more confident and well-spoken when speaking in public."

Be Personal. Make affirmations personal and meaningful to you. They should resonate with your values and aspirations, not someone else's.

Be Repetitive. Finally, consistency is key! Repeat your affirmations daily, ideally multiple times a day, to reinforce the positive messages.

The goal of an affirmation isn't to repeat something that is false – for example, if you are struggling with a health issue, you wouldn't say, "I am in perfect health!" You might say something like "I am getting better and better every day!" or "I don't need to feel perfect – I have all the energy I need to make this day a great one." An affirmation is simply phrased

around the end goal, the part of your mind that you *can* control, reminding yourself that you are making progress.

For example, when I was a player, I needed to hear I wasn't alone, so I would always repeat to myself "You're not alone. You've got great coaches and teammates that are working towards the goal with you."

You also want to take advantage of confidence anchors. Confidence anchors are simply visual reminders of confident feelings. Maybe it's a medal from the last time you ran a half-marathon, to remind you can do challenging things. Maybe it's a coffee mug someone gave you the last time you crushed a key project that makes you feel like a boss whenever you look at it! Think about a time when you felt exceptionally confident and empowered and select a physical object or image that you can associate with the positive experience.

Confidence – and learning how to actively grow your confidence – is key to anyone climbing with success, male *or* female. So, let's learn more.